

KEYBOARDS

There's a lot that goes into making a keyboard than just special function keys. The feel of a keyboard is essential as the focus is high on being ergonomic and user friendly. Split keyboards are a prime example of this. These keyboards are split down the middle and consist of two halves. This allows your hands to assume a more natural and comfortable position, with support for the elbows. As the most widely used input device, keyboards have gone through many small, yet meaningful changes to make the job of typing as easy as possible.

In the time to come, keyboards will go through various enhancements to make them even more ergonomic and will pack in more features such as built-in speakers and scanners. This trend of integrating components onto keyboards is expected to continue. That isn't to say that radical changes won't be in order. Touch-sensitive keyboards are currently under development as are biometric-enabled models. But for the common user, the conventional 101-key keyboard will remain on desktops for years to come.



Logitech Cordless Freedom Navigator

Every feature that you could possibly think of, and some you simply couldn't, in a keyboard

This cordless, multimedia-enabled keyboard uses radio signals to communicate with the base unit, giving you the freedom to move around. Its buttons are made of special rubber to provide a better grip, which makes it very comfortable to type, especially during long stretches of work. Another highlight is the power saving feature to save the battery life of the cells used in the keyboard. There are a plethora of settings and functions that can be assigned to the programmable buttons, making it a highly utilitarian and configurable device.

+ Excellent features
+ Freedom to use in any direction
Price: Rs 7,900
Contact: Rashi Peripherals

Phone: 022-8260256-59
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E-mail: ho@rptechindia.com
Reviewed in: July 2001

Worthy Mentions

Microsoft Internet Keyboard Pro
+ Multiple number of programmable hotkeys (19)
+ 2 USB ports
Price: Rs 2,900
Contact: Mnemonic Systems
Phone: 8010871
Fax: 8051761
E-mail: mnemonic@vsnl.com
Reviewed in: July 2001

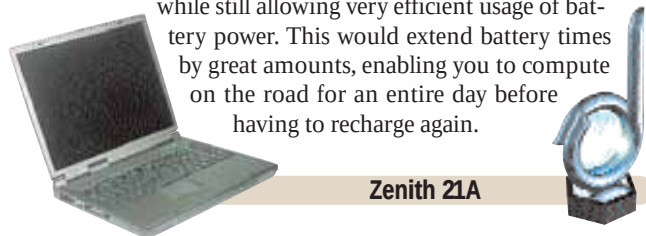
Samsung SDL1500
+ Excellent build quality
+ Great value for money
Price: Rs 400
Contact: Samsung Electronics India
Phone: 011-6322517/18/19
Fax: 011-6932607
E-mail: marketing@samsungindia.com
Reviewed in: July 2001

PREVIOUS WINNERS 2000: ACER Airkey 1999: Logitech Cordless 1998: NA

LAPTOPS

With increasing computing power in mobile devices, the line differentiating laptops and desktop systems is getting increasingly thinner. With integrated DVD and CD-RW drives, large 14-inch TFTs and very serious processing and graphics capabilities built into them, the laptops of today can very well replace, or in some cases even surpass, your desktop computers. Newer technologies such as 802.11 wireless networking and Bluetooth are becoming more visible on today's notebooks, thus further increasing their portability and functionality.

The catchphrase in the laptops of tomorrow is going to be portability and even smaller profiles and form factors with increasing processing power. Newer technologies such as Banias, which will help design processors that use far lesser amounts of processing power, will help laptops of the future boast of gigahertz speeds while still allowing very efficient usage of battery power. This would extend battery times by great amounts, enabling you to compute on the road for an entire day before having to recharge again.



Zenith 21A

A powerful graphics subsystem and ample processing power for both office and professional applications

With a good processor, 128 MB of RAM and a spacious screen, this laptop is well suited to processor-intensive applications such as image processing. Also, the robust S3-based graphics subsystem enabled it to deliver very commendable results in gaming. This system was also replete with manuals and other peripherals such as a separate mouse, making it a very complete and feature-rich package. With a sturdy build quality, this notebook will give you the power required to take demanding applications on the road.

+ Excellent performance; Lots of detailed manuals
Price: Rs 1,00,000
Contact: Zenith Computers

Phone: 022-8377297
Fax: 022-8377300
Reviewed in: January 2001
E-mail: mumbai@zenith-india.com

Worthy Mentions

IBM ThinkPad Transnote
+ Compact innovative design, touch sensitive screen
+ Electronic scribble pad for handwritten input
Contact: IBM India Limited
Phone: 080-2079999/3333
Fax: 080-2079311
Price: Rs 2,30,000
E-mail: lsawkar@in.ibm.com
Web site: www.ibm.com

Sharp AX-20 (March 2000)
+ Good performance
+ Very small form factor
Price: Rs 1,20,000
Contact: L&T
Phone: 022-2884412
Fax: 022-2853577
E-mail: it-sharp@ltbkh.lindia.com
Reviewed in: March 2001

PREVIOUS WINNERS 2000: ACER TravelMate 602TER 1999: ACI Profile 1998: NA